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Peking,

No 198. 16th September 1874.

My Lord,

I trust that my telegram of the 11th, to the effect that, in my opinion, our squadron out here ought to be reinforced, will not have unduly alarmed Her Majesty's Government. In this country of contradictions I have seen it again and again happen that when the atmosphere appeared so charged as to make a storm inevitable, things went on, notwithstanding, much

The Earl of Derby
etc. etc. etc.

Sir Rade to
Prince of King.

Inclosure 2
in Mr Wade's
No 197
of Sept 18 1874

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much as before. We have here at this moment, however, an unusual concurrence of complications.

First, there is the Japanese complication. The Japanese continue to occupy the south part of Formosa, declaring that part of the island not to belong to China; and, as is proved by the Commissioner Okubo's recent statement to myself, they have no idea of retiring. The Chinese

Chinese Government angrily protests that the whole island is Chinese, and appeals to foreign governments to denounce the proceedings of the Japanese as unreasonable. It goes no farther, believing, doubtless, by the light of Chinese education, that reason, if demonstrated to be reason, must prevail. It admits its complete incompetence at once to expel the Japanese. It is obliged to receive a minister of the power that it maintains has seized its territory. He will probably have his Audience like the rest. Meanwhile, both China and Japan are making

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making to the best of their ability preparations for war. But with marked inequality in the completeness of these preparations. The Japanese have strengthened themselves in fastnesses said to be impregnable. They have nationalised a Chinese outlaw of some importance, who was driven a short time ago to rebel by certain acts of oppression. The Aborigines and Chinese outlaws, were the Chinese army to sustain a reverse in the field, would, in the opinion of a foreigner competent to judge, immediately join the Japanese

Japanese against the Chinese. The Japanese garrison, in the stronghold above mentioned, is said to be victualled and munitioned for fifteen months. Foreigners of different nationalities speak of their camp and hospital establishments as deserving of high praise. The naval forces of Japan, on the other hand, though it includes one or two large vessels, is stated to be very unfit for war.

The Chinese, however, although their small vessels are supplied in some instances with

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with superior artillery, have nothing fit for sea but smaller craft, which, again, they have not crews to work; and if war were declared, would be made powerless by the withdrawal of the foreigners who now command and sail their gunboats for them. A very smart Englishman, in command of one of these boats, who has every reason for desiring that China rather than Japan should win, has been known to observe that unless the Chinese

Chinese crews have a twelvemonth's education before war breaks out, the fleet they man will be all destroyed. His sole consolation is that the Chinese vessels are in general faster than the Japanese.

On shore, the condition of China is worse. Troops ordered to embark at Chinkiang for Formosa, a few weeks since, refused, and were replaced by reputed ex-rebels and recruits newly caught. They are armed at random and wholly without organisation. The information on which I am relying, and it is made up from the letters and reports of various

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various foreigners, some of them for every reason well affected to the Chinese, justifies the belief that were the Japanese suddenly to strike a blow, it would be successful. That their intentions are not pacific is plain. It is not only that they are manifestly determined to retain territory which the Chinese declare to be theirs, but that on this very point they hold different language to Sir Harry Parkes and to myself; and whether their purpose be to make war soon or late, the all but certainty that

War

war is impending, is nearly as injurious as if a blow had been struck.

This brings me to the second of our complications. The country, though in a fashion restored to the Government, is full of rebellion. The south of the empire is notorious for its affiliated Societies. The vicinity of Amoy is a special home of these, and in a very recent note from Mr. Pedder, he expresses his conviction that were the troops of China known to have sustained a defeat, there would be

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a general rising round
Amoy. The Governor of
Chek Kiang within the last
few weeks has reported to
the Throne that his province
is constantly troubled by
Societies of different denominations.
The vocation of these Societies
is brigandage, but they have
always a political badge.
What we have to expect from
this source of evil has
been shewn in the last month.
When I brought the rumor
of a massacre that was to
take place at Tientsin
on the 8th August to the
notice of the Prince of
Kung,

Kung, I received a note to the
effect that people's minds
were disquieted by the
warlike movements of the
Japanese. A fortnight later
is discovered the projected
rising of a considerable
portion of the force under
immediate command of
the Governor General, the one
officer in the empire whose
leadership I should have
esteemed a fair guarantee
against a danger of the
Kind. The deserters who were
to have seized Tientsin are
still at large in sufficient
force to affect the safety
of communications between
this

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this and Tientsin; or, more
properly, to alarm the native
travellers. The sergeant and a
Constable of our Escort
returning last week from
Tientsin with treasure, could
not prevail upon their boatmen
to push on by night for this
reason. They anchored near
the larger market towns.

I have myself no
doubt that were the belief
to become general that the
Japanese were about to
invade the coast, (as in
the middle of the 16th century
they did,), there would be
such a subversion of
authority throughout the Empire
as

as would paralyse trade, if
it did not seriously affect
the personal security of the
port communities.

And this brings me to
the third of our chief causes
of embarrassement; I might
say the chiefest cause; viz. the
complete unfitness of the
Central Government to deal
with such a domestic difficulty.
Were it menaced by foreign
war, it is competent to take
one step. The forts of Ta-Kee
would, now so far check an enemy
that, until the forts were
turned by land, a fleet
would

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would not easily force its
way up the river to
Tientsin. Against sedition,
which might shew itself in
the Capital as probably as
anywhere else, it would
prove absolutely helpless.
It has no man nor set of
men equal to the emergency,
and the latest act of the
Emperor, his capricious
degradation and hasty
reinstatement of the
Prince of Kung, must
have discredited and
disheartened the small Knot
of statesmen who, with the
Prince at their head, have
been, since 1861, in charge
of

of the administration of
domestic and foreign affairs.

Whether Japan will
very presently strike a
blow I do not venture to
predict. But a few weeks
ago I thought that war
would come on us at once,
and I did my best to make
the Central Government understand
its danger. Then there appeared
a disposition to arrange the
difference between the two
powers by a money payment.
But if the Japanese ever
seriously entertained the
notion of being bought out
of Formosa, this notion has,
I think, been abandoned.

They

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They have had time to study the weakness of this Government. Their foreign agents keep them well informed. Some of these, naturally, are very anxious for war. Lastly, the Chinese authorities in the provinces, while most unguardedly denouncing to all and Sundry the proceedings of the Japanese as hostile and illegal, avow with equal unguardedness their utter unreadiness for war. There is everything, therefore, to tempt Japan to follow up what she has begun. But whether

whether she more farther or not, so long as her troops remain as at present in Formosa, so long, we may be sure, will China continue dreamily to ponder their expulsion. This state of things, which is neither peace nor war, is perhaps more dangerous from the inducements it offers to the disaffected to disturb the Empire within, than from the opportunity it affords to its foreign enemy. But, I repeat, and this is of course my particular care, our trade and the security of our communities stands as fair a chance of being jeopardised

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jeopardised, by the protraction of this state of uncertainty, as by open war.

I believe that I have not exaggerated the threefold difficulties of the situation. At the same time, to end as I began, I do not pretend to affirm that there will be war. Orientals deal together on principles of their own. Neither am I predicting an insurrection, nor the immediate collapse of what may be called the Prince of Kung's administration, though its new lease

of

of life may be but a short one. I must admit, indeed, that in the thirty odd years that I have passed in China, no incident has occurred to my mind of the same gravity, all circumstances considered, as this late outbreak of Imperial wrath. It shews upon what a thread hangs the life of the Empire.

Nothing could have happened at this moment more calculated to produce a general feeling of insecurity.

It must be for your Lordship to decide whether or not I have proved my case. As my telegram related

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related to a matter directly
concerning the Naval
Commander in Chief, I
shall confidentially communicate
copy of this despatch and
the despatch reporting my
conversations with the
Japanese Commissioner
Okubo to Sir Charles
Shadwell.

I have the honour to be
My Lord,
with the highest respect,
Your Lordship's most
humble obedient Servant
Thomas Francis Wade.

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Peking
23. September 1874.

No 199

My Lord,

In continuation of my Despatch, No 183, of the 3rd Instant, reporting what I had been able to learn about the projected rising at Tientsin, I have the honor to forward copy of an interesting Report from Mr Walter, the Interpreter momentarily in charge

The
Earl of Derby

at

Peking, 16th Sept.
Rec. Sept.
No 198

Received Dec 4

General view of state of affairs in China. - Particulars as regards war with Japan. Japanese in Formosa. Sedition. Security of the Ports.

The Viscount
Sir A. Buchanan
Peking

586. A copy of this despatch has been already communicated to the Admiralty by Mr Hammond's direction.

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